Den of Lions (Stigmata)

By Terry Anderson

INTRODUCTION

What is it like to exist for seven years in darkness and chains, not knowing from one day to the next how much longer you will be a prisoner? Or if you will be released from captivity the next day – or killed. Terry Anderson, chief Middle East correspondent for The Associate Press, was abducted in Beirut, Lebanon on March 16, 1985. Physically imprisoned, beaten, treated more as an object than as a human being, Anderson found out how the human spirit can reach beyond the bars of prison. These poems were written by Mr. Anderson during his captivity, set to memory and then recorded after his release in Den of Lions by Terry Anderson.

STIGMATA I

Seven years in chains
while love lies barren,
while children grow;
one lost, one not known,
and others left unseeded
now will never be.
Grim, terrible years
In subterranean cells,

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a pawn of evil hypocrites;
passed from hand to hand
across the Muslim archipelago,
Taped and bagged like
some dead meat, despised,
inedible, but useful in trade.
Harsh and painful years
of darkness, damp and dirt,
humiliations heaped in myriads,
hatred and contempt received, returned.
Wasted, empty years? Not quite.
No years are empty in a life;
and wasted – that depends on
what is made of them, and after.

STIGMATA II

Pursuing idle pleasures,
abruptly snatched by wild
fantassins waving guns,
pushed and pulled down
from the sunny heights
into a darker world
where venomed voices
whisper menace and blows
erupt out of the night.
There's no appeal;

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the laws and judges
of this court are ruthless,
mercy's alien and justice
twisted out of shape.
A man is just a thing
to be abused or not or
any whim or aim, or none.

STIGMATA III

Early endless weeks,
chained, blindfolded.
Each small movement brings
a curse, a threat, a blow.
Sometimes the vultures
gather around to poke and
prod with talon, stick, or gun,
mutter maledictions and
predict an early, painful end
they don't impress; no thief
throws away his booty.
More frightening are the
vultures of the mind.
Remorse, regret circle
through the night alighting
each in turn to tear
a tasty morsel from the soul.

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There's much that vultures love --
noisome, rank, and nasty.
Petty vices, packets full of lies,
Soft overripe indulgences,
and rankest, juiciest of all,
Selfish pain inflicted
on an open, trusting heart.
The leavings of this carrion feast
are meager, unimpressive:
Some kindnesses, bits of charity,
Aa few small acts of real love,
and heaps of good intentions;
all strung together by
the only thing of value here --
a steel determination to survive.

STIGMATA IV

Prayers in the night hurled
fiercely at an absent God;
pleas, promises, bargains offered,
but no answers. Not until
each act in life's examined
and acknowledged; remorse, regret
put in their proper places --
commendable but useless.
Then, after hours of cold

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and bitter honesty, into
exhausted calm comes a presence,
softly, almost timorously,
of warmth and light and love.
It will not stay; recoils
from each new blast of anger;
flees absolutely from
hatred's demon glare,
but leaves behind a longing,
comfort, and all anguish
smaller than before.
No flawed man, beset by passion
can hope to hold it long
Though some rare souls
bathe often in its glow.
For most, a light,
Infrequent touch, perhaps
just once a life,
must be enough.

STIGMATA VI

Isolation ends; other denizens
of this mad gulag bring relief
and aid in staving off
the savages without, within.
Self-flagellation can be purifying,

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but carried on too long becomes
indulgence, a twisted kind of pride.
New minds bring fresh air;
new shoulders can be leaned on;
new regards provide a scale,
a balance that makes it easier
to maintain both faith and hope.
Personalities and politics
are different; five egos
in a room must clash and rub.
But differences are unimportant
next to shared laughter and shared pain.
Each takes from each;
each gives of what he has.

STIGMATA VI

Evil dealt with daily
becomes familiar, even ordinary.
At first just faceless and
malefic minions, guards
become distinct and separate.
Some are petty, mean, and vicious,
other ordinary, even sympathetic.
Communication can begin,
and some small understanding,
but soon runs into walls of

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background, belief, and circumstance.
The logic is too different;
mental language untranslatable.
There's no shared view of God or man.
Oppressor and oppressed,
Each sees the other
a victim bound and blind.

STIGMATA VII

A six-foot chain, a six-foot cell
allow t wo paces: step, step,
and turn; step, step, and turn.
When the body's bound,
the mind leaps free to soar
and twist and turn back
on itself until its very freedom
becomes a kind of prison.
Each emotion's felt in
fierce intensity, swelling,
fading only to return again
on a wild, unpiloted
roller coaster ride
that never ends, ignoring
pain, sickness, even death,
devouring all without a pause.
Time's fragmented, each moment

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endless, unconnected to
the swiftly passing years.

STIGMATA VIII

As in all prisons, information
is both punishment and weapon.
All news is censored; none allowed
at all for weeks, then glimpses
granted of family, friends' concern.
Finally the game apparently
grows tiresome. Without a word,
a radio appears, magazines, even
television, and the world crashes in.
Not the one abandoned --
this is a frantic, changing place.
Wars, disasters, famines are
different, but the same.
What startles are the images
of empty-handed people defying tanks;
of nations by the score
reclaiming freedom; the abrupt
irrelevance of long-held enmities,
old alliances, and once-feared weapons;
of history resuming its
awkward, stumbling climb.

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STIGMATA IX

Companions leave; new friends
arrive only to go home in turn,
Stirring hope, envy, and frustration.
Negotiations start, stumble,
stop, and start again
as each participant gropes a
and grasps for small advantages>
But slowly, it becomes apparent
that the roller coaster ride
has neared its end.
Soon it will be time to
leave this unamusemet park.
What of the man who will emerge,
pale, shocked by the images
cast from distorted mirrors?
Better, or worse?
Or like the world
that greets him,
unchanged in essence,
but shake into new relations
with himself, and others?

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STIGMATA X

No man can ever start anew completely;
he's everything he's done
or said or failed to do.
Each bit is added on,
Altering the whole,
But covering, not replacing
what has gone before.
A piece of unfired clay,
he bears the marks
and scars of all his years.
Not just clay, though
sculptor, too;
he helps to mold himself:
Object, artist, audience.
Sometimes, though, larger hands --
destiny, fate, karma, God --
take firmly hold and,
wielding fierce events,
risk fracture to hack
and carve away some
awkward, ugly bits.
The final work cannot be seen
until it's fired, and all fires cold.

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Paul knew: suffering and pain
are the truest ways,
the only ways for some of us,
to draw out that within
which answers to
the purpose of it all.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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